



FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS — LABORATORY TESTS AND RESULTS

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Dept: Pathology (Block B, Level 2) and Radiology (Block B, Level 3) |

Valid Until: 31 December 2026

BOOKING AND PREPARATION

Do I need a referral to request a laboratory test?

Most laboratory tests require a referral from a registered medical practitioner. Self-referral is accepted for a limited range of wellness screening tests, including full blood count, fasting blood glucose, lipid profile, and basic thyroid function. The laboratory reception at Block B, Level 2 can advise on which tests are available without a referral. For imaging such as CT, MRI, and ultrasound, a medical referral is required in all cases.

How should I prepare for a blood test?

Preparation depends on the specific test ordered. For most routine blood tests such as a full blood count or thyroid profile, no fasting is required. For fasting blood glucose and lipid profiles, patients must fast for at least 8 to 12 hours respectively, with water permitted throughout. For a glucose tolerance test, an 8-hour fast is required before arriving; the procedure involves multiple blood draws over two hours. Patients are advised to confirm preparation requirements when booking.

Is home sample collection available?

Yes. Home visit sample collection is available for blood and urine tests within the Colombo District, Monday to Saturday from 6:00 am to 10:00 am. Advance booking is required by calling 0112-456-770 at least one day prior. A home visit fee is applicable in addition to the cost of the tests. Samples collected at home are processed under the same conditions as those collected at the laboratory. Home collection is not available for specialised tests requiring immediate processing.

What should I wear for an MRI scan?

Patients are advised to wear loose, comfortable clothing without metal components such as zips or underwire. All metallic items including jewellery, watches, hearing aids, body piercings, and hair accessories must be removed before entering the MRI room. A hospital gown will be provided if required. Patients with any implanted metallic devices, including pacemakers, cochlear implants, or surgical clips, must notify the radiology team in advance. The presence of certain implants may contraindicate MRI scanning.

Do I need to fast before a CT scan?

Fasting is not required for non-contrast CT scans. For contrast-enhanced CT scans, patients must fast for at least four hours before the procedure and provide a recent creatinine result to confirm kidney function before contrast administration. Patients with diabetes on metformin must follow specific instructions regarding temporary discontinuation of the medication around the time of contrast administration, which will be provided by the radiology team.

RESULTS AND FOLLOW-UP

How long do results take?

Most routine blood tests are available within two to four hours of sample collection. Hormone panels and tumour markers take four to eight hours. Microbiology cultures require 24 to 72 hours depending on the organism. Genetic

and molecular tests processed by our partner laboratory take seven to 14 working days. Radiology reports for X-rays are typically ready within two hours; MRI and CT reports within 24 hours.

How do I collect my results?

Results may be collected in person from the laboratory or radiology desk on presentation of a valid NIC or hospital registration card. Results are also available through the Serendib patient portal within one hour of verification. If the referring doctor is a Serendib consultant, results are transmitted directly to their patient file without any action required by the patient. A printed copy is available on request at no additional charge.

Can results be sent directly to my doctor?

Yes. Results are automatically transmitted to the referring consultant's patient file within the hospital's electronic system. If the referring doctor is from an external clinic or hospital, a printed report may be faxed or sent by courier upon written request. Patients must provide the receiving doctor's contact details and fax number at the time of registration.

What happens if my results are abnormal?

Abnormal results are reviewed by the responsible pathologist or radiologist before being released. Critical or markedly abnormal values are communicated directly by telephone to the referring consultant without delay. Self-referred patients will be contacted by a clinician before results appear on the portal. Patients are advised not to interpret abnormal results independently and should seek clinical guidance before drawing any conclusions.

Can I request a repeat test if I am unsure about the result?

Yes. Repeat testing may be requested through the referring doctor, who will assess whether clinical grounds justify repetition. Some borderline results warrant repeat testing as part of standard medical practice, while others are best interpreted in context rather than repeated. Self-funded repeat tests are accepted with a valid medical referral.

Are my results stored and for how long?

All investigation results are stored in the patient's hospital record for a minimum of seven years in accordance with regulatory requirements. Digital records on the patient portal are accessible to the patient indefinitely during active membership. Patients wishing to export their full investigation history may do so from the portal under My Records, or request a printed summary from the Medical Records Office.

Can I get a second opinion on my radiology report?

Yes. Second opinions on radiology reports may be arranged within the department by requesting a review by a senior or subspecialty radiologist. Patients may also seek an external second opinion, in which case the original imaging will be provided on a CD or via secure digital transfer upon written request. A fee may apply for digital transfer to external institutions.

P. Mendis

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